



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Cornerstone Classical School
School Website: <https://cornerstonebasalt.net/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Cornerstone Classical School Co 81621 (Basalt, CO 81621) presents a strongly faith-centered, family-partnered educational community. Public-facing materials repeatedly frame the school as a Christian, classical-leaning program with an emphasis on character formation, biblical worldview, and community partnership. The site highlights daily Bible-prayer-worship routines, a statement of faith, and a leadership emphasis rooted in Christian discipleship, with explicit mentions of partnering with families through structures like a School Advisory Committee (SAC) and opportunities for parent engagement. While the school clearly affirms a Christian, formation-based aim and includes elements commonly associated with classical education (e.g., Latin, apologetics, structured middle-school debate), it relies on a denominational-curriculum approach (notably Bob Jones University Curriculum) rather than a canonical classical framework centered on Great Books, liberal arts grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, or explicit Socratic pedagogy across its K–12 program. On balance, this evaluation rates Cornerstone Classical School as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL overall, with clear CLASSICAL markers in religious foundations and parent/community engagement, but limited alignment with core classical curriculum-pedagogy signals and Great Books emphasis.

Executive summary — category-by-category snapshot: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL - Purpose and Goal: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Curriculum: NOT CLASSICAL - Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: Concrete steps to advance toward full CLASSICAL include (1) articulating and adopting a formal Great Books/great-conversation component across grades, (2) signaling and documenting explicit grammar-logic-rhetoric progressions (especially in upper grades) and Socratic/seminar pedagogy, (3) expanding any liturgical/communal practices into a more explicit “scholé” rhythm (restful contemplative learning) while maintaining doctrine-rich identity, and (4) clearly mapping public-facing materials to the “positive keyword” framework in the Six Essential Elements document (e.g., Partnership with Families, Formation of Affections, Cultural Transmission). These changes would align more fully with the classical rubric while preserving the school's Christian distinctives.

ABSTRACT section appears at the end of this report.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents a robust Christian framework: “A Christian school ... spiritually and academically equips ... to be leaders” and explicit Christian identity throughout (Cornerstone CC School materials). - Daily spiritual practices are highlighted: “We start every day with Bible, prayer, and worship” (preschool/k-12 pages). - A Statement of Faith and a theology-forward vision anchor the curriculum (Statement of Faith page; Jeremiah 29:11 in staff bios).

- The Vision emphasizes educating “children in the history and values of Christian faith” and forming a Christian worldview for thinking about truth, goodness, and the world. - The School Advisory Committee reflects liturgical/community alignment with a pastoral dimension (pastor, principal, parents, community).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed (mapped to the Six Elements): Theology/theological study (theology), Transcendent moral realism (virtues anchored in Scripture), Liturgical/Communal Practices (Bible/prayer/worship), Partnership with Families via community governance (SAC with pastor/parents), Biblical foundation (biblical worldview). See citations above. - Negative keywords: None (no explicit signs of “Lack of Partnership,” “Lack of liturgy,” or secularized theology) in public-facing materials.

Why this rating - The materials consistently articulate a metaphysical frame rooted in Christian theology, sacramental/communal practice, and a covenantal form of character formation, aligning solidly with the Positive Keyword indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. The presence of a Statement of Faith, daily worship, and pastor-led community governance supports a CLASSICAL rating in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school's stated aim includes formation and moral formation through Christian virtues, with an emphasis on leading students to live out a Christian worldview and to be leaders who impact their world. Statements emphasize formation over mere information and a virtue-oriented aim. Example phrases include “spiritually and academically equips, challenges, inspires” and a focus on forming character within a faith context. - There is explicit talk of “forming students” and a moral/spiritual formation language (e.g., “history and values of Christian faith,” “Christian worldview” in the Vision). - Public materials emphasize partnership with families and community as a formation context (SAC and parent-tour processes).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Partnership with Families (via SAC), Formation of Affections (implied through worship/prayer and moral formation language), Cultural Transmission (Christian heritage and worldview). - Negative keywords observed: None overtly present in public materials.

Why this rating - The school clearly frames education as formation with a virtue-centered aim and a Christian worldview, which aligns with “formation” and “truth-goodness-beauty” moral formation. However, explicit articulation of classical aims centered on liberal-arts virtue-maximization (virtue and wisdom as primary outcomes independent of strictly Christian framing, and explicit reference to the classical liberal-arts progression) is less pronounced in these public materials. Therefore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL best captures the balance: formation-centered with clear classical-adjacent elements, but not a fully explicit classical framework in purpose language.

What would move this category to CLASSICAL - Add explicit language that education aims at the cultivation of virtue and wisdom in the classical sense (truth, goodness, beauty) as timeless ends independent of job preparation, with direct references to “formation” as the central goal. - Include explicit articulation that the mind can know truth, goodness, and beauty in order to inform the curricular aim (the Great Conversation language is present in the classical rubric but not yet echoed in mission/purpose statements).

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum references a denominationally framed program: “The Bob Jones University Curriculum” is used in Preschool through Elementary and explicitly noted in Curriculum & Assessment. This is a historical Christian curriculum model, not the classical liberal-arts canon that centers on grammar-logic-rhetoric and Great Books. - Narrative mentions of Latin, apologetics, and STEM are present, but there is no explicit Great Books or Great Conversation framework. The middle-school description emphasizes debate and logic, but there's no explicit Great Books or canonical classical curriculum sequence. - The site describes a Christ-centered worldview, the use of STAR assessments, and a variety of activities (Latin,

STEM, arts), but it does not clearly present the liberal-arts architecture (grammar-logic-rhetoric progression; historical breadth via Great Books; a concerted “first grammar, then logic, then rhetoric” pathway).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Latin, apologetics, biblical worldview, STEM, literature/reading in the Christian framework, STAR assessments. (These are present but do not map cleanly to the classical “grammar-logic-rhetoric” triad or Great Books.) □filecite□turn0file2□turn0file12□ - Negative keywords observed: Great Books/Great Conversation (not evidenced); Scholé/restful learning (not evidenced as a guiding pedagogy); explicit grammar-logic-rhetoric progression (not clearly described as such).

Why this rating - The curriculum relies on a denominational program (Bob Jones University Curriculum) rather than a canonical classical curriculum that centers on liberal arts grammar-logic-rhetoric and Great Books. While there are classical-adjacent elements (Latin, debate, apologetics) and a strong faith integration, the absence of a clear Great Books framework and explicit classical pedagogy signals a NOT CLASSICAL classification for Curriculum.

What would move this category toward CLASSICAL - Adopt and publicly document a classical curriculum framework that foregrounds grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, explicit memorization and recitation (Scholé), and the Great Books or canonical Western texts as core reading across grades. - Provide a transparent cross-walk showing how Great Conversations and core texts programmatically integrate with science, mathematics, history, and literature, including explicit examples of graded memory work and recitation.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Middle School is described as “the age of debate” with a block schedule across 6–8th grade, emphasizing logic and the whys of knowledge and God’s role in life. This signals a movement toward dialogic and reasoned inquiry. - The middle-school note mentions “discipleship and mentorship from staff” and “serving within the CCS community,” signaling mentorship-based pedagogy with some Socratic flavor (debate and logic-focused inquiry). Upper-level rhetoric training is not explicitly described, but there is an emphasis on discussion and logic in middle school. - There is no consistently explicit mention of Socratic seminars or structured rhetoric practice across grades, nor a stated commitment to regular memorization/recitation in lower grades (Scholé). The content emphasizes a faith-based, practical, and disciplinary approach rather than a formal classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic discussion (implied by “debate” and “logic” in the middle-school description), discussion-based learning, rhetoric training mentioned as an upper-school possibility (though not explicitly described in practice). The language indicates a shift toward inquiry-based pedagogy in at least some grade bands. - Negative keywords observed: None explicitly named (no declarations of overly rigid, purely job-prep pedagogy; no explicit “Lack of Scholé” wording).

Why this rating - The presence of a debate-oriented middle school and emphasis on logic suggests a move toward classical-style pedagogy in parts of the program, but the absence of explicit, school-wide implementation of Socratic seminars, rhetoric-centered upper-level instruction, and a clearly stated grammar-logic-rhetoric progression means the overall pedagogy is not fully classical. Hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move this category toward CLASSICAL - Implement and publicly document a formal classical pedagogy across all grades, including: - A clear grammar-logic-rhetoric progression from K–12. - Regular Socratic seminars, debates, and rhetorical exercises in upper grades. - Explicit memorization and scholé routines (restful, contemplative study) embedded into daily/weekly schedules. - A plan showing how language arts, history, and literature center around canonical or Great Books selections and guided discussion.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site presents individual faculty bios (e.g., Kathy Whiting, Principal; Anika Neal, 3rd Grade; Cailyn Raper, 6th/7th Homeroom; Casey Adams, PE) with personal faith statements and professional backgrounds, indicating qualified teachers who model virtue and faith. Public bios emphasize a Christian orientation and long-tenured teaching experience.

- There is a mention of a Pastor-led or faith-integrated leadership approach and a School Advisory Committee including pastors and parents, which supports a community-centric faculty model. - However, there is no explicit public articulation of the faculty as “the living curriculum” or a defined faculty portrait of teacher-student ideal, beyond individual bios and leadership titles. The materials do not present a formal “faculty profile” or a codified vision of teacher-student archetypes beyond the bios.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Model teachers and mentors (implied by long-tenured staff bios and prayerful language in bios), “living curriculum” (not explicitly stated in these materials; absence noted). - Negative keywords observed: Absence of explicit “living curriculum” framing or a explicit faculty portrait (as per the Six Elements document) in public-facing materials.

Why this rating - The public-facing materials show capable, faith-driven teachers and leadership but lack explicit claims that the faculty embody a formal classical faculty identity (e.g., “the living curriculum,” a portrait of teacher-student ideals, or collegial, mentor-driven faculty culture beyond individual bios). This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

What would move this category toward CLASSICAL - Include explicit statements and public-facing pages that present: - A formal **faculty portrait** describing the teacher as “the living curriculum.” - A statement on faculty collaboration and mentorship as core to the school culture (not just individual bios). - Alignment of teacher professional development with classical pedagogy imperatives (grammar-logic-rhetoric mastery, memorization, memory work, and Great Books exposure in appropriate grade bands).

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school strongly emphasizes partnering with families and involving parents as co-teachers through structures like the SAC, which includes pastors, parents, and community members. This is explicitly aligned with the “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections” strands in the classical rubric. - The site invites parent involvement (tours, enrollment forms, and community engagement) and provides mechanisms for parental education and involvement (SAC; opportunities for parents to get involved; “Take a Tour” and enrollment communications). - The public materials present a robust, faith-led community emphasis, with a Christian liturgical rhythm and a mission to pass on a Christian heritage and educational formation to families, which maps well to Positive keyword indicators for Partnership with Families and Cultural Transmission. □filecite□turn0file0□turn0file4□

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Partnership with Families, Parent partnership, family involvement, school-family collaboration, community of learners, parental engagement, parental leadership, tour/visit access for families, formation of a shared mission. - Negative keywords observed: None (no signs of limited parental access or separation from home life in public materials).

Why this rating - The school’s public-facing materials foreground parent engagement, family partnership, and community involvement. The SAC structure and explicit invitations for families to participate strongly align with the classical category Positive keywords in this dimension, justifying CLASSICAL for Element 6.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school advances toward a fully CLASSICAL profile (moving from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in multiple categories), it should consider:

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- Implementing a formal Great Books or canonical reading program with a documented Great Conversation framework, and making explicit how Great Books concepts are introduced and discussed at various grade levels.
 - Establishing and publicizing a grammar-logic-rhetoric progression across K–12, with explicit memorization/recitation practices (Scholé) in lower grades and Socratic seminars in upper grades.
 - Building a public-facing “living curriculum” narrative for Faculty (Element 5)—a formal portrait of teachers as the living curriculum and a collaborative faculty culture anchored in classical pedagogy.
 - Extending the pedagogy to explicitly demonstrate Socratic dialogue, seminars, or debates as standard practice in more grade levels (beyond the stated middle-school emphasis) and articulating a plan for rhetoric training in upper grades.
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Aggregate Assessment

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Rationale - The strongest CLASSICAL signals come from Element 1 (Religious Foundations) and Element 6 (Parents & Community) and the explicit Christian formation orientation running through the program. Element 2 shows formation-focused aims that resemble classical ends, while Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy) reveal classical elements but lack full canonical classical structure (Great Books, clear grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, and universal Socratic pedagogy). Element 5 shows faculty strength and faith integration but lacks explicit public articulation of a “living curriculum.”

- The combination of strong religious formation and family/community partnership with partial but incomplete classical pedagogy/curriculum signals yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating overall.

Notes on evidence and sources - Religious foundations and liturgical practices are evidenced by daily Bible-prayer-worship, Statement of Faith, and a faith-centered vision and staff bios (cite turn0file13; turn0file9; turn0file4; turn0file17). - Curriculum and pedagogy signals include the Bob Jones University Curriculum and middle-school emphasis on debate/logic, with Latin/apologetics present but no explicit Great Books or canonical classical curriculum (cite turn0file12; turn0file2). - Faculty signals rely on bios and leadership structures but lack a formal “living curriculum” framing (cite turn0file17; turn0file2). - Parent/community signals are strong via SAC structures, tours, and engagement opportunities (cite turn0file2; turn0file0).

Citations to relevant file_search results (representative samples) - Core public materials: Cornerstone Christian School statements, worship practices, and mission: turn0file0, turn0file13, turn0file4, turn0file9, turn0file17. - Middle-school pedagogy and curriculum references: turn0file2. - Curriculum framework (Bob Jones University Curriculum): turn0file12. - Parent/community structures (SAC, parent involvement): turn0file2. - School profile and Basalt, CO location data: turn0file6, turn0file7, turn0file11.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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